His innings had started with breezy cognisance of the helpful conditions. As prime minister of Pakistan since August 2018, Imran Khan would often refer to his government and the country's powerful army being "on the same page". And his supporters thought it perfectly normal to gloat about what they referred to as his "hybrid government"—an open acknowledgement that the military was an equal partner in an ostensibly civilian government. Even if Imran made mistakes during his tenure as prime minister—and he made many—he could always rely on the army to back him up and clean up after him. The military tempered not just his erratic governance but also managed the political wheeling-dealing required to keep his rag-tag coalition of allies, his own party 'electables' and a boisterous opposition in line. But then, the military stepped back, and the house of cards came crashing down.



UNITED AGAINST THE CAPTAIN
Opposition leaders (from left) Bilawal Bhutto-Zardari, Khalid Maqbool Siddiqui, Shehbaz Sharif and Maulana Fazlur Rehman at a press conference, Mar. 30

On April 3, facing a near-certain ouster through a vote of no confidence in the National Assembly (NA), Imran orchestrated what can only be termed a farcical face-saver—his hand-picked NA Deputy Speaker Qasim Suri summarily rejected the vote proceedings, claiming a "nexus" between "blatant foreign interference" and the motion. Subsequently, Imran recommended the dissolving of the assembly, thereby ending his three-and-a-half-year-old "hybrid experiment".

Although Imran did his best to portray losing the prime ministership as a victory, the fact remains that not only was he forced out prematurely from office, he also faces charges of subverting the constitution—from all indications at the time of this writing, the Supreme Court is likely to rule that Imran and his party broke the law and went against the constitution in attempting to illegally dismiss the vote of no confidence. This could yet lead to further legal repercussions.

It has been a dramatic fall from grace for Imran, who thought he could do no wrong. So what *did* go wrong?

TOO BIG FOR BORROWED BOOTS?

When the former cricket superstar, playboy-turned-philanthropist-turned-Islamist and perennial opposition politician finally swept into power in 2018—after "22 years of political struggle", as he would keep reminding everyone—most observers felt his had not been an organic victory won fair and square.

It was an open secret among journalists that the military had played a decisive role in breaking away 'electable' candidates from other parties and bringing them over to Imran's side through inducements or pressure. In fact, the covert backing of the military was alleged from at least 2014, when Imran called out large crowds in long-running dharnas to try and topple then PM Nawaz Sharif's government.

Similarly, smaller parties were arm-twisted into forming a coalition with Imran's Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI) after the 2018 election. PTI had emerged as the single-largest party in the NA with 155 seats, but 17 short of the 172 needed for a simple majority to form a government in the 342-member assembly. Imran put together a coalition of seven other parties and an independent member to take the tally to 177, enabling him to lay claim to form the government.

Despite his government's slim majority in the NA and despite several blunders and crises, the coalition government endured, partly because of a deflated opposition, but mostly because Imran's real backers did all the trouble-shooting for him. Now, his former allies who have deserted him—such as the mainly Karachi-based Muttaheda Qaumi Movement (MQM) party, which has seven seats and whose move into the opposition camp proved symbolically decisive—openly talk about how they used to receive phone calls from officers within the military ordering